Technical Report: Cybersecurity Awareness Guide

Oct 25, 2026 · @Imran Khan

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Objective and background

The objective was to create a practical cybersecurity awareness guide of 2 to 3 pages for university students and early-career staff. It had to cover phishing, social engineering, suspicious links and attachments, impersonation, urgency tactics and safe reporting, with realistic but fictional examples.

Background: phishing and social engineering remain among the most common ways accounts are compromised, and new students and employees are frequent targets because they handle many new accounts and unfamiliar official messages.

Research and methodology

I reviewed public guidance from CISA, the UK National Cyber Security Centre, the US Federal Trade Commission, the Indian Cyber Crime Portal and CERT-In. From these I selected the most common warning signs and response steps, and wrote them in plain language for non-technical readers.

Tools used: Claude (an AI assistant) to help draft and structure the guide, which I then reviewed and edited; a web browser for research; Google Drive for sharing.

Method: (1) read official guidance, (2) list common attack types and red flags, (3) write three fictional scenarios, (4) add a response checklist and reporting steps, (5) review for clarity and length.

Work performed and findings

The finished guide contains: purpose and introduction, definitions of phishing and social engineering, a section on links, attachments, impersonation and urgency, six warning signs, three fictional examples with correct responses, a six-step "what to do if you

clicked" section, reporting steps for India, a conclusion and five references.

Findings from the research:

- Almost every phishing message relies on urgency, a request for credentials or money, or an unexpected link or file.
- Checking the sender through a separate trusted channel is the single most effective habit.
- Fast reporting limits damage, so the guide tells readers that reporting is never a mistake.

No software was built and no security testing was performed for this task.

Limitations and recommendations

Limitations: The guide has not been tested with real readers. All examples are fictional. Reporting steps are specific to India and would differ elsewhere. Attack methods change quickly, so the guide needs regular updates.

Recommendations:

- Test the guide with a small group of students and collect feedback.
- Add a short quiz or simulated phishing exercise, run only in an authorised environment.
- Review and update the examples every six months.

Conclusion and references

The task produced a clear, practical awareness guide that gives readers a simple routine: stop, check, report. The main lesson from the research is that awareness of a few common red flags prevents most phishing attacks.

1. CISA, Recognize and Report Phishing: https://www.cisa.gov/secure-our-world/recognize-and-report-phishing
2. UK National Cyber Security Centre, Phishing: https://www.ncsc.gov.uk/collection/phishing-scams
3. US Federal Trade Commission, How to Recognize and Avoid Phishing Scams: https://consumer.ftc.gov/articles/how-recognize-and-avoid-phishing-scams
4. National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, India: https://cybercrime.gov.in
5. CERT-In: https://www.cert-in.org.in